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The Nuba

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 240

Culture (OWC): [Nuba \(FJ21\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1938-1941

Coverage Date: 1938 AD - 1941 AD

Place Coverage: South-Central South Kordofan, Sudan

Section Title(S): Adolescence And Adulthood

There is, too, female circumcision, which balances the adoption of the boys' circumcision. It is not (or not yet) practised on an equal scale: it is universal in arabicized Tira Mande, and has been adopted by a few families in Kalkadda. It has not yet penetrated to the other hills, although I was told by people in Kattei (in 1938) that they, too, intended to circumcise their girls. A number of men in other hills (e.g. Kora) have married circumcised girls from Kalkadda and Mande. But only in Mande do we find already the positive discrimination in marriage in favour of circumcised brides which is typical of Arab communities. I cannot go here more fully into the social, psychological, and medical implication of this custom. Let me only state that the girls are circumcised at the age of twelve to fifteen, that the circumcision is of the severe type known as 'pharaonic', in which the labia majora are completely removed, and that the operation is performed by a woman expert, without apparent ill effects. It is performed at the same time of the year, as the boys' circumcision, often together with the latter, and similarly celebrated by a family feast and dances of girls and women.¹

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There is no thought in Moro of modelling the life of girls and women on that of the men or of prescribing parallel courses for male and female adolescence. Save perhaps in one respect: we find again the special girls' sport of the *lepido rora*. The Moro girls fight with real leather whips as well as with heavy iron bracelets worn on the left wrist. But though more severe, the girls' fighting in Moro, is, socially, less important than in Tira; the whip-fights take place irregularly, accompanying, as improvised sequels, the stick-fighting tournaments of the young men. Change of name, ritual events, and certain mutilations mark off the important phases in the physical and social life of girls and women. The young girl is called *nere* till she reaches puberty. When

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she has passed through the  241 ritual which surrounds her first menstruation she becomes known as *nwa*. About this time she will be betrothed and, when her bridegroom has made the initial bride-price payment, has her lower incisors broken out. The only reason which the people can give for this mutilation is that 'it looks nice'. In the fourth or fifth month of pregnancy, before moving into her husband's house, she is cicatrized. Finally, when she has borne her first child, she changes her name again, being henceforth known as *uži*, 'wife'.¹

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¹ We shall return to this 'borrowed' institution, which, in my view, is bound to strengthen its hold, in the more general context of Chapter XII.

¹ Let me add by way of a footnote and without comment that the Moro perform clitorodectomy on girls with a large, projecting clitoris. This 'disfigurement', clearly visible as the Moro girls wear nothing over their pudenda, is considered ugly and gives rise to ribald jokes-hence the operation.

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